In the interaction, we collectively presented numerous issues from every corner of Maharashtra. We flagged issues, including the need for sustainable development, redressing unemployment, combating communalism and methodically bridging the gap between power and people. Some of us were astonished at how deeply he engaged with us, without displaying any fatigue despite the gruelling schedule. He was also swatting away efforts by a couple of leaders to curtail the interaction or to stop us from raising some issues.

The same situation recurred in the walking interaction. Rahul did not just take me along, he also took the Narmada movement along with him. The few steps we took together, and the hour-long discussion on broad issues, made BJP leaders lose their sleep. He was genuinely attentive, even in short conversations with Leilabai or Noorji Bhau, who were fighting in the valley of Lavasa and Narmada. Rahul mentioned that he hoped to establish a permanent platform within the party for constant dialogue and collaboration with people's movements and social organizations. In that spirit, he asked for our advice on how to build a platform. He was eager to hear from us about our lessons in dealing with the ruling dispensation, which many of us strongly felt only pretended to be a people's party but did not work for the people or the country. He earnestly heard and understood our feedback on this matter.

We all submitted diverse petitions to Rahul, which he passed on to his team and organizers. Although it was natural that he might have to set aside thousands of similar petitions and applications across India, we all hoped that he would act on them and provide an alternative to the country. If he did that, those millions of others who couldn't reach the Yatra but were engaged in struggles at the state, district and block levels would have hope in the near future. This is a question (and hope) that was and still is in the minds of many people.

Someone even posed this question to Rahul. His response was honest and measured. He said, 'Do not expect miracles from just one person—things will not change that easily. I do not believe it ... And I also know that we have not fallen short in any way, and you all are standing strong before